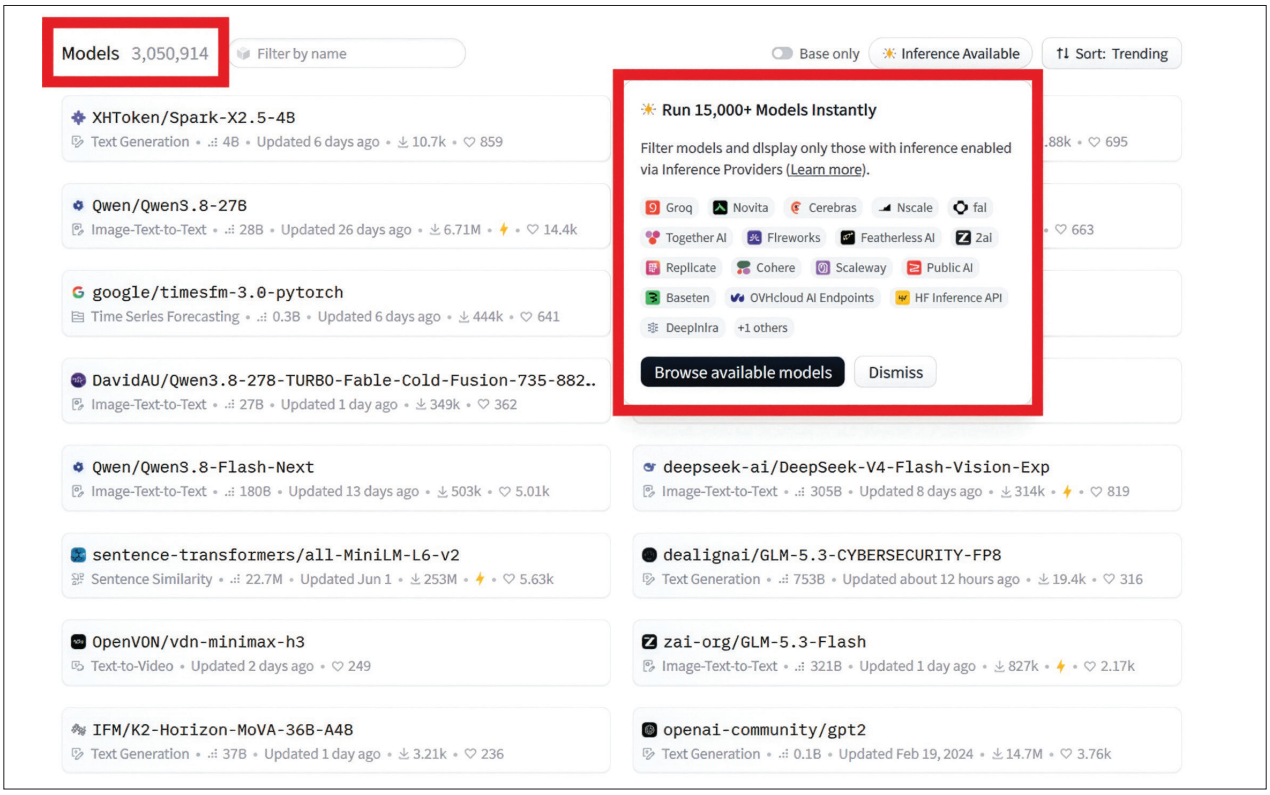


Check the uploader name. Look for a recognised organisation page. Follow links from the developer's official site or announcement where possible. Then use the original page as your reference point while comparing derivatives.

Community conversions are not inherently suspicious. They are essential because a developer may release Safetensors weights while another contributor produces the GGUF quantisations required by llama.cpp-style runtimes. What matters is understanding the chain:

original model → conversion or fine-tune → exact file you download.

If you cannot establish that relationship, slow down.

Step 3: Read the Model Card before Files

The most useful file in many repositories is also the smallest: `README.md`.

Hugging Face renders this as the Model Card. Its documentation says a good card should describe the model, intended uses, limitations, biases or ethical considerations, training information, training datasets and evaluation results. Metadata can also expose fields such as task, language and licence.

Do not assume every card is complete. Quality varies.

Read it in this order:

1. **What is this model?**
   Confirm architecture, parameter count and whether it is base, instruct, reasoning or multimodal.
2. **What is it designed for?**
   A research checkpoint is different from a general-purpose assistant.
3. **Which languages does it support?**
   "Multilingual" is useful; named languages and actual evaluations are better.
4. **What context length does it support?**
   Note the maximum and any recommended setting.
5. **What software is recommended?**
   The card may specify Transformers, llama.cpp, vLLM, Ollama or a minimum library version.
6. **Are there special prompting instructions?**
   Some models need a particular chat template, system-message format or reasoning switch.
7. **What are its weaknesses?**
   A candid limitations section is a positive sign.

By the time you open Files, you should know why you are considering the model.

Step 4: Treat benchmark numbers as evidence

Many model pages include evaluation results. Hugging Face now supports structured evaluation data that can appear on model pages and benchmark leaderboards, with indicators for results that are verified, community-provided or linked to a benchmark.

Useful, yes. A substitute for judgement, no.